MANNING ZHANG

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EDUCATION

Expected Aug. 2027 Joint Ph.D. in Social Policy and Sociology, Brandeis University

May 2023 M.A., Social Policy, Brandeis University

Jun. 2020 B.L., Sociology, Fudan University; Minor Certificate, French Language, Shanghai International Studies University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Medical sociology; obesity; science and technology studies; sociology of knowledge; technology governance; comparative public health; pharmaceuticalization; fitness; physical activities; qualitative methods; China studies.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed Articles

Ressler, R., Zhang, M., Leonardos, M., Noelke, C., & Acevedo-Garcia, D. (2026). Structural Racism, Neighborhood Opportunity, and Racial/Ethnic Disparities in Homicide Risk. (Preprint: https://www.medrxiv.org/content/10.64898/2026.06.29.26356868v1)

Haque, Z., Zhang, M.(co-first author), Meschede, T., & Warfield, M. (2026). Undoing the STEM/non-STEM Boundary: Exploring Women's STEM-Related Experiences. *Gender, Work & Organization*, *33*(6): 2171–2184.

Zhang, M., Ressler, R., Noelke, C., & Acevedo-Garcia, D. (2025). Disparities in Violent Deaths by Neighborhood Opportunity with the Child Opportunity Index 3.0. *AJPM Focus, 4*(4):100357.

Ma, R., Zhang, M., Oakman, J., et al. (2021). Eating disorders treatment experiences and social support: Perspectives from service seekers in mainland China. *International Journal of Eating Disorders, 54*(8), 1537–1548.

Ma, R., Oakman, J., Zhang, M., et al. (2021). Lessons for mental health systems from the COVID-19 frontline. *Traumatology, 27*(4), 432–443.

Book Chapters and Reviews

Zhang, M. (2025). Gamification of Fitness and Training. In J. Bustad & G. Abeza (Eds.), *Technology, Sport and Recreation: Physical Activity in the Digital Age.* Routledge.

Zhang, M. (2024). Review of Steven Epstein (2022): "The Quest for Sexual Health: How an Elusive Ideal Has Transformed Science, Politics, and Everyday Life." *Sexualities, 28*(1-2), 748-750.

Selected Policy Reports

Meschede, T., Stewart, S., & Zhang, M. (2026). Leveraging Mobility in Boston: Economic Well-Being and the Flow of Wealth Across Three Generations. Institute for Economic and Racial Equity, Brandeis University. https://heller.brandeis.edu/iere/pdfs/racial-wealth-equity/leveraging-mobility/leveraging-mobility-in-boston-compressed.pdf

Loya, R., Smith-Gibbs, M., & Zhang, M. (2023). Increasing Access to Postsecondary Education Savings: Strategies for Designing Equitable 529 Programs. Institute for Economic and Racial Equity, Brandeis University. https://buildcommonwealth.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/CW_Increasing-Access-to-Postsecondary-Education-Savings.pdf

Selected Public Writings

Xie, Q., & Zhang, M. (2026). Early-Stage Financing for Hard-Tech Startups in the Yangtze River Delta. ThePaper.cn (in Mandarin). https://m.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_34066468

Zhang, M. (2024). What Is the Boundary of Global Health? Open-Air Journal. https://openairjournal.substack.com/p/what-is-the-boundary-of-global-health?r=1ez6az

Zhang, M. (2024). Climate Change and Green Gentrification. Open-Air Journal. https://openairjournal.substack.com/p/climate-change-and-green-gentrification

WORK IN PROGRESS

Zhang, M. "What Became of the Movement? The Politics of Obesity and Weight Control in China." Dissertation monograph in draft.

Zhang, M. "Re-politicize Health: Intersected Inequities in Health Knowledge Production and Application." Under revision; to be submitted to Sociology of Health & Illness.

Zhang, M. "Centralizing lifestyle in status-making." Under revision; to be submitted to Sociological Inquiry.

Zhang, M. "Fitness as a Temporal Craft: A Two-Wave Interview Study of Exercise in Early Adulthood." Awarded the 2026 NASSS Barbara Brown Outstanding Student Paper Award (Doctoral Category); to be submitted to Leisure Studies.

Zhang, M. "Building Community Through Fitness: The YMCA and the Social Life of Exercise." Drafting.

Zhang, M. "Making Sense of Fitness and Health: Young Adults' Understandings of Well-Being in Campus Recreation Spaces." Drafting.

TEACHING AND MENTORSHIP

Primary Instructor

2025 Summer Quantitative Research Methods (undergraduate 4-credit seminar), Brandeis University.

2024 Fall Divergent Identity: Unraveling China's Traditional and Modern Cultural Phenomena (5-class series), Brandeis Osher Lifelong Learning Institute.

2024 Summer Observing the Social World: Doing Qualitative Sociology (undergraduate 4-credit seminar), Brandeis University.

Teaching Assistant

2021–2024 Introduction to International Relations; Order and Change in Society; Health, Community and Society; Basic Statistics for Social and Political Analysis; Sociology of Body and Health; Sociology of Education; Sociology of Reproduction, Brandeis University.

- For most of these positions, I assist the instructor in leading discussion or software practice sessions, grading, taking attendance, and supporting students during office hours.

Mentorship

2022–2025 Writing Fellow, Brandeis University Writing Center.

- Provided one-on-one writing consultation to Brandeis undergraduate and graduate students with different racial, cultural, and academic backgrounds.
- Designed and taught university writing workshops on research strategy, structural writing, revision, and time management.
- Led a team of over 10 graduate writing consultants to provide writing support.

2024 Fall Graduate Writing Assistant, Brandeis University Student Support Services Program (TRIO)

- Provided writing-related advice to first-generation college students from resource-restricted backgrounds.

2023–2024 Undergraduate Research Lead Mentor, Brandeis University (leading a team of 18 graduate and undergraduate students).

- Led the peer research mentor team of 18 graduate and undergraduate students.
- Provided personalized research support such as identifying ideal mentors, preparing for academic conferences, brainstorming research ideas, for over 30 rising undergraduate researchers.

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2026 "The Politics of Health Knowledge Production: Intersectional Inequities and Obesity Governance in China." British Sociological Association Medical Sociology Group Annual Conference, Newcastle upon Tyne.

2025 "Re-politicize Health: Intersected Inequities in Health Knowledge Production and Application." American Sociological Association Annual Conference, Chicago.

2024 "Not by Accident: The Technological Production of Embodied Health Inequalities" and "Undoing the STEM/non-STEM Boundary." ASA Annual Conference and SSSP Annual Meeting, Montréal.

2024 "Status: A Hierarchy of Honor" and "Understanding Health Technology and Inequality" (in Mandarin). Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference, Harbin.

2024 "Unveiling the Impact of Bike Infrastructure on Urban Neighborhood Transformation in the Greater Boston Area." Boston Area Research Initiative Conference, Boston.

2024 "Boston Moving: Fitness Clubs and Community-Making Practices." ASA Community and Urban Sociology Section Virtual Mini-Conference.

2024 "Tackling the Bamboo Ceiling: Experience of Early-stage Immigrant Asian Women Scholars in the United States." Education & Health Research Hub Conference, George Mason University.

2023 "Fit for Good: Contested Social Class, Gender and Racial Contexts in the Weight Room." American Sociological Association Annual Conference, Philadelphia.

2023 "The Migration Old: Exploring Chinese Senior Rural-Urban Population in the Past 30 Years with the Age-Period-Cohort Model." Population Association of America Applied Demographic Conference, Annapolis.

2022 "Asian Women in the Weight Room." Eastern Sociological Society 91st Annual Conference, Boston.

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

2026 Barbara Brown Outstanding Student Paper Award (Doctoral Category), North American Society for the Sociology of Sport ($1,000 and conference fee waiver)

2026 Wyatt Jones and James Schulz Dissertation Grant, Brandeis University ($3,000)

2026 Berkowitz Dissertation Research Prize, Sociology Department, Brandeis University ($600)

2026 Roberta L. Lipson '76 and Ted Plafker Endowed Travel to China Fund, Brandeis University ($2,500)

2026 Heller School Student Dissertation Enrichment Fund, Brandeis University ($3,000)

2024 Social Justice Internship Fellowship, Brandeis University ($2,956)

2024 APPAM Equity and Inclusion Fellowship, Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management ($1,389)

2024 Sagan Family Grant for Graduate Research, Brandeis University ($1,000)

2024 Three-Minute Thesis Competition First Place Prize, Brandeis University ($1,000)

2024 Provost Doctoral Research Award, Brandeis University ($1,000)

2023 GSAS PhD Research Award, Brandeis University ($1,000)

2022 GSAS Connected PhD Career Development Fellowship, Brandeis University ($12,000)

2022 Peter Conrad Award for Graduate Student Pre-Dissertation Research, Brandeis University ($600)

2018, 2020 Undergraduate National Scholarship (GPA #1), Fudan University ($1,000)

2019 Excellent Paper Award, Shanghai Sociological Association Annual Conference

SELECTED RESEARCH POSITIONS

Nov 2024 – Apr 2026 Retirement and Mobility Qualitative Researcher, Institute for Economic and Racial Equity, Brandeis University. Supervisors: Sylvia Stewart and Tatjana Meschede.

Nov 2024 – Dec 2025 Disability Policy Qualitative Researcher, Lurie Institute for Disability Policy, Brandeis University. Supervisors: Anne Valentine and Lauren Smith.

Oct 2021 – May 2025 Quantitative Research Intern, diversitydatakids.org, Institute for Child, Youth and Family Policy, Brandeis University. Advisor: Clemens Noelke and Robert Ressler.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

2024–2026 Student Representative, American Sociological Association, Culture Section.

2023–2024 Student Representative, American Sociological Association, Decision-making, Networks, and Society Section.

2021–2026 Editorial Board Member, American Sociological Association, Sociology of Culture Section Newsletter.

SKILLS

Software: R, Stata, NVivo, ATLAS.ti, SPSS, ArcGIS, Python, Adobe Creative Suite

Languages: Mandarin (native), English (professional), Spanish (basic)

REFERENCES

Dr. Laura J. Miller (Dissertation Committee Chair), Professor of Sociology, Brandeis University | lamiller@brandeis.edu | (781) 736-2643

Dr. Siri Suh, Associate Professor of Sociology, Brandeis University | jssuh@brandeis.edu | (781) 736-2635

Dr. Christine E. Bishop, Professor, Heller School for Social Policy and Management, Brandeis University | bishop@brandeis.edu | (781) 736-3942

Dr. Tatjana Meschede, Associate Director, Institute for Economic and Racial Equity, Brandeis University | meschede@brandeis.edu | (781) 736-8678